

HSS652: Select Themes in Contemporary Global Political Thought

Response Paper

Can Rousseau's ideal of the General Will realistically exist in a diverse society? Is it inherently democratic or potentially authoritarian?

Jean Jacques Rousseau's "The Social Contract (1762)" revolves around the idea of "General Will". Even though the concept accounts for the welfare of all, it could be manipulated when the motive behind it gets compromised, especially in diverse societies. It calls for a democratic establishment but has the potential to become authoritarian if the ideals of a good social contract and citizens become corrupt.

According to Rousseau, "sovereignty belongs to the people, and the government is only a representative of the sovereign, charged with executing the general will". Although he never offered a singular and comprehensive definition of general will, he described it according to the requirements of an argument. The concept of "General will" is essentially "the law emanates from the people themselves", in other words, it emphasizes that an ideal society looks after the welfare of "people" by working out "common good", agreed upon by all and for all. Its execution is parallel to the idea of democracy, where the people elect their representatives, and the representatives make laws and govern public welfare. In a democracy, decisions are procedurally majority-based, but the constitution aligns them to constitute the general will. Rousseau prioritizes general will over individualism, as it will compromise the "better for all" for a "best" for one but "worse" for another. Individuality is exercised more by egoists or people who value amour propre more than societal good, as they are more influential and aware to use freedom in their favor, which makes them "corrupt". According to him, these are often due to advancements in science and the arts, which are distractions and corrupt people from morality. These ideas received both applause and criticism from various contemporaries, Daniel Bell remarks "The price of equality [in the Social Contract] is... that 'an individual can no longer claim anything'; he has no individual rights; 'his person and his whole power' are dissolved into the general will"; the French appropriated the concept and its associated values for its "Declaration of the Rights of Man".

Realistically, the success of such settings in a state depends on the size of the state, diversity, the procedure used, etc. General will can be defined more precisely in a smaller society, as it is easier to involve everyone, and arriving at a conclusion that suits everyone

is faster. However, in a larger society, the diversity in all social, cultural, and ideological aspects increases, due to which decision-making becomes more complicated and slower. Often conflicts arise for opposing opinions, where the majority might overrule after calculating the general will, even though everyone has equal rights, or the minority might dominate by other means, which paves the way for authoritarianism. An example of such conflicts could be the debate over the legality of abortion, people are divided whether abortion should be legal or not as some believe it is a sin, it being a god's gift; others have the opinion of reserving the right to the woman, as the physical, mental and emotional issues faced during pregnancy should not be forced as her body doesn't belong to anyone else. Adoption rights for non-heterosexual people are another topic of conflict among people. Sometimes, conflicts like these lead either to no conclusions or to forcing a law based on the biases of the leaders authoritatively. It suggests that, realistically, general will cannot exist in diverse societies.

It is also possible for the chosen leaders to become corrupt, and they start prioritizing their individual will, creating bridges between people while benefiting a section. Rousseau critiques in his *Lettres écrites de la montagne*, depicting it as a tyrannical city-state with "twenty-five despots". The point of the general will is to make a "good man" by this measure – to make citizens order themselves for the whole, rather than precisely the opposite, which suppresses its citizens. It illustrates his critique of established political systems when they fail to uphold the general will. A recent example of such a system was seen in Nepal, where the masses, along with the mobs, decided to overthrow the government as the "rich" had become corrupt while the people suffered. Rousseau occasionally seeks to channel forces he finds supportive of the general will, such as fraternity and nationalism, which is reflected in the situation of Nepal.

A society should be run in a democratic manner where every citizen is equal and has a say in the decision-making through representatives chosen by the people in favor of the general will, but the contemporary scenario reflects all sorts of degeneracy in the form of authoritarianism, despotism, and tyranny over public welfare; everyone has become self-centered and wants to be virtuous. Even the democratically chosen representative betrays the people or are weak willed to support their people, like the privatization of many government establishments in India by the Modi-led government, or the rise of the Taliban in Afghanistan and suppression of women in the reformed law in Afghanistan, which are in favor of the general will, according to the sovereign of that state.

Therefore, in order to keep society going for good, regular amendments to the laws or procedures should be made, and representation of people from all diverse groups must be ensured. With the advancements in internet, new procedures in which the people could be part of decision making could be introduced which can be improved as and when required like the new "sovereign" in Nepal was elected on an online platform, although

the method was not ethical but it could be improvised in a way that connects leader and people directly and a good social contract could be formulated.

Even on a smaller scale such system failures could be seen for example, although the authorities were not chosen democratically by the stakeholders, IISER Mohali maintained a good social contract favoring general will initially with the involvement of everyone in discussions in spaces like 'open houses' and a common good was identified beneficial for all but with increase in diversity the system has shifted to authoritarian rule.

All these instances suggest that realistically general will's concept could be harbored easily when the diversity is less, corrupt when the diversity increases. In my opinion, the concept of general will is admirable, but it's for an "ideal society" where people are not corrupt. Even in a democracy, diversity among people has a great influence on decision-making as well as the fellow beings; it might lead to manipulative and unnecessary delays hampering society's progress and development. Diversity also creates hierarchy among people, and individuality becomes more prevalent, which pushes it toward an authoritarian model. However, the procedures could be revised to make things more inclusive and supportive for all.

Summing up, general will is related to morality ideally. When people are moral, the general will is inherently democratic, but as soon as someone becomes immoral, the general will becomes authoritarian as they influence the system, no matter the demographics as it will then depend on the influence and dominating ability of immoral beings. I believe that a society is inherently democratic in its initial stages, but as it progresses and diversifies, it ends up becoming authoritarian if the system is not checked on time.

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